

A Sham

Implementation of the dry policy is at best a farce

Though the state is officially dry, liquor is often served at weddings and big parties.

Illicit liquor outlets are known as "daru stands". To open one, unofficial permission is granted by the police who get a share of the booty from hooch sales.

Both IMFL and country liquor are available in plenty. IMFL is smuggled in from Rajasthan and Maharashtra. The business is said to be worth Rs 1,400 crore while the country liquor business is entirely local.

All popular brands available at prices 40 to 60 per cent more than the neighbouring states.

No worries if caught. Punishment for selling or drinking is the same: a Rs 25 fine.

A YOUNG BOY PERFORMS THE LAST RITES OF HIS FATHER, A VICTIM OF SPURIOUS LIQUOR

MODI RUSHED TO MUMBAI AFTER 26/11 BUT HAS NOT YET VISITED THE FAMILIES OF THE DECEASED.

who kept a stoic silence however, except to issue a brief statement condoling the deaths. A desperate state Government, on the other hand, tried to take corrective measures by first setting up a commission under retired high court judge Kamal Mehta to look into the causes of the tragedy and suspending or transferring a few police personnel. The tragedy also triggered public protests for the first

time in Modi's eight-year rule. The protesters burned buses and vandalised public property.

This ugly episode has revived the old debate over the state's controversial policy with the anti-prohibition lobby claiming that not only is it the biggest source of corruption in the police, it also leads to an annual loss of nearly Rs 3,000 crore to the exchequer. The pro-prohibition lobby, comprising old Gandhians and a section of Gujarati business class, cites prohibition as the reason for the domestic and industrial peace in Gujarat and a relatively good law and order situation. The pro-prohibitionists feel the policy needs stricter implementation. Says Chunibhai Vaidya, a Gandhian and social worker: "The relaxation of the prohibition law will ruin Gujarat. The Government should break the police-bootlegger nexus to ensure stricter implementation."

Gujarat has seen several liquor tragedies in the past few years. In 1977, over a hundred persons died in Ahmedabad, while in two hooch-related tragedies within the next decade, more than 150 people died. Killer brews claimed 132 lives in Vadodara in 1989 and there have been many smaller incidents over the last decade. A year ago, the Modi Government had relaxed the prohibi-



tion policy to some extent by allowing liquor in SEZs and even groups outside SEZs to attract investment, but there were loud protests from social workers and the pro-prohibition lobby. Subsequently, Modi is said to have been advised that relaxing the law to make liquor openly available at shops would prove politically suicidal as a vast section of Gujarati women support prohibition.

**Khane mein
kya hai?**



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